

As part of the European project ARC II (AWARENESS RAISING CAMPAIGN FOR SMEs (ARC) – Campaign to Raise Awareness of Data Protection for Small and Medium Enterprises), an international conference was held on April 9, 2024, in Rome, which brought together representatives of the Croatian and Italian data protection supervisory authorities, the academic community, small and medium enterprises, and personal data protection experts.

The main goal of the ARC II project, which the Agency has been implementing since September 2022, is to develop IT solutions tailored to the specific needs of Croatian and Italian micro, small, and medium enterprises, and to facilitate their compliance with the legislative framework for personal data protection. The IT solution, namely the web tool "Olivia," has been created in open-source code and is available for free use by all micro, small, and medium enterprises and data protection officers. The coordinator of this project is the Agency for Personal Data Protection, while the partners include the Italian data protection supervisory authority (Garante Privacy), the Faculty of Organization and Informatics from Varaždin, Vrije University from Brussels, and the University of Florence.

In his introductory address, the director of the Agency, Zdravko Vukić, thanked the project partners, as well as the European Commission for recognizing the value of the project proposal and entrusting support for its implementation. "In Croatia and Italy, as well as throughout the EU, small and medium enterprises account for over 90% of businesses, making them the backbone of the European economy. They also represent the largest group of data controllers and processors who handle vast amounts of personal data. The key message I would like to send to small and medium enterprises today is that investing in data protection and information security is no longer an option, but a necessity. The GDPR does not represent an administrative burden or an obstacle to technological development; on the contrary, it serves to promote responsible development and use of artificial intelligence that does not harm individuals and their fundamental rights and freedoms," said Director Vukić, emphasizing that the personal data of each individual is their valuable asset.

Although the web tool "Olivia" is the main project outcome, in order to assist small and medium enterprises, the Agency has also organized 22 workshops on various topics such as artificial intelligence, information security, processing personal data through cookies, how to prepare for Agency oversight, etc. Due to the high interest from entrepreneurs who register for the workshops and have the opportunity to resolve their uncertainties during the sessions, the Agency will hold five more workshops.

Project manager, Head of the EU, International Cooperation, and Legal Affairs Sector, Anamarija Mladinić, spoke about the challenges faced by small and medium enterprises in the Republic of Croatia and the experiences from the ARC II project. She highlighted that the biggest challenge of the project was developing content for 15 modules for Olivia, which must meet the needs of all small and medium enterprises. "Their needs are very diverse. For example, the needs of financial institutions such as insurance companies, which are also small enterprises, or polyclinics, are quite different from the needs of a beauty salon or a flower shop. For some of them, the modules are very simple, while for others, they are quite complex, so it was very demanding to achieve the right balance. I believe we have a good product that can help entrepreneurs."

The web tool Olivia contains a small online academy that offers entrepreneurs a series of learning modules to improve their knowledge in the field of personal data protection and also serves as a practical tool to assist in the creation of internal acts to demonstrate their compliance and reliability.

The ARC II project is a continuation of the successfully implemented ARC I project and is co-financed by the European Union program "Citizenship, Equality, Rights, and Values," Grant Agreement number 101072630. The planned duration of the project is 24 months, from September 2, 2022, to September 2, 2024.